

RESEARCH ARTICLE

Unpacking the relationship between leaders' age and active conflict management: The moderating role of generativity

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Abstract

As organizations face an ageing workforce, it is crucial to understand the role of leaders' age in their interactions with employees. Seminal theories on ageing cast age as a key factor shaping individuals' interpersonal behaviours, for example when handling conflicts. We integrate this notion with insights from generativity research to investigate the role of leaders' age in their active conflict management strategies through two distinct pathways. Depending on a leader's generativity, leaders' age may differentially shape both their perceptions of leader-member exchange (LMX) quality and their emotion regulation knowledge, thereby advancing either more constructive or more destructive approaches towards employee conflicts. Results from Study 1, a time-lagged study of 303 leaders, revealed that age is negatively related to their LMX perceptions and, thus, to leaders' constructive approaches towards employee conflicts—but only among leaders with lower generativity. Study 2, a cross-sectional study of 84 leader-employee teams, revealed that leaders' age is positively associated with their emotion regulation knowledge, which in turn is negatively related to their destructive conflict management—but only among leaders with higher generativity. Our findings reveal key mechanisms linking leader age to conflict management and underscore leader generativity as a crucial boundary condition in these relationships.

KEYWORDS

conflict management, emotion regulation knowledge, generativity, leader age, LMX perceptions

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The ageing workforce is a prominent trend in today's organizations, making it crucial to understand age-related differences in employee behaviour (Kearney et al., 2022; Nargund, 2009; Walter & Scheibe, 2013). One area where age plays a significant role is conflict management (for a review, see Beitler et al., 2018). Ageing has been associated with socioemotional changes that foster an appreciation for harmonious interactions, potentially leading to reduced tensions and conflicts (Birditt et al., 2005; Carstensen, 2021). And indeed, research has consistently found a positive relationship between individuals' age and conflict avoidance (Beitler et al., 2016).

Notably, however, avoidance is a pronouncedly passive strategy of conflict management (De Dreu et al., 2001). Although sometimes beneficial, it may not be effective in situations that require more active approaches, in which avoidance may merely postpone (and potentially escalate) the conflict at hand (Saeed et al., 2014; Yang, 2014). Leadership is a prime example of a context that frequently necessitates deliberate, active conflict management (Chandolia & Anastasiou, 2020). After all, leaders need to maintain favourable employee relations, coordinate team task accomplishment and maintain employees' motivation and performance (de Waal-Andrews & van Vugt, 2020). Therefore, leaders are often required to actively manage imminent conflicts with employees to bolster their team's effectiveness (Guttman, 2004; Zhou et al., 2020). Consequently, it is vital to understand how leaders' age shapes their use of *active* conflict management strategies.

Scholars have highlighted three types of active conflict management (De Dreu et al., 2001): *Problem-solving* is a constructive strategy that entails high concern for both oneself and others, aiming to integrate the conflicting parties' goals to arrive at mutually beneficial solutions. This strategy emphasizes collaboration and information sharing to achieve win-win outcomes. Similarly, *compromising* is also a constructive strategy, although it entails only moderate concern for oneself and others. It involves finding middle-ground solutions through mutual concessions to satisfy both parties' needs, for example when mutually optimal solutions are unlikely (Fisher & Ury, 1981). *Forcing*, by contrast, is a potentially destructive strategy of conflict management that involves high concern for oneself but low concern for others (De Dreu et al., 2001). This strategy is competitive, aiming to maximize one's personal gains at others' expense.

Prior research has produced inconsistent results on the role of age in active conflict management. Studies on problem-solving strategies, for example, report positive (Balay, 2007; Beitler et al., 2016), negative (Yeung et al., 2015) and non-significant age relations (Beitler et al., 2018; Birditt & Fingerman, 2005). Similarly, studies on compromising yield both positive (Bergstrom & Nussbaum, 1996; Grossmann et al., 2010, 2012) and non-significant linkages with age (Balay, 2007; Grossmann et al., 2012). Finally, studies on forcing strategies also show mixed results, with either negative (Birditt et al., 2005; Birditt & Fingerman, 2005) or non-significant age associations (Beitler et al., 2018; Yeung et al., 2015; Zapf et al., 2019). Moreover, it is important to note that these studies have been conducted outside a leadership context which, as noted before, may put a premium on active strategies of conflict resolution (Guttman, 2004; Zhou et al., 2020). Overall, we, therefore, conclude that there are two critical problems in the existing literature: First, little is known about the specific role of *leaders'* age in the active management of conflicts with their employees—although it is clear that such conflict management is crucial for leadership success (Kazimoto, 2013; Saiti, 2015). Second, the existing literature on age–conflict management linkages in contexts other than leadership is highly ambiguous, thus offering little guidance on the possible consequences of leaders' age.

To address these issues and better understand leader age–conflict management linkages, it is essential to clarify the generative mechanisms underlying them. Hence, an important focus of this investigation is to unveil such indirect relationships. For example, socioemotional selectivity theory (SST) suggests that as individuals age and perceive their time as more limited, they increasingly value emotional fulfilment in social encounters (Carstensen, 2021) and thus prioritize meaningful, high-quality relationships over peripheral and instrumental ones (English & Carstensen, 2014; Lansford et al., 1998). Accordingly, it is possible that older leaders may perceive their LMX relations (i.e., the degree of liking, trust and respect in their relations with employees; Liden et al., 1997) in a more positive light, which may critically shape their approach to conflicts (Dulebohn et al., 2012;

Landry & Vandenberghe, 2009). Furthermore, the strength and vulnerability integration model (SAVI; Charles & Piazza, 2024) proposes that individuals develop advanced emotional competences as they get older. As people age, in particular, they may benefit from accumulated learning and practice effects and, thus, become more adept at understanding and managing emotions (see also Doerwald et al., 2016)—and this increased emotion regulation knowledge may enable older adults to manage conflicts more effectively (Beitler et al., 2018; Schlaerth et al., 2013). Applying these insights to leadership contexts, older leaders' proactive conflict management may benefit from their improved emotion regulation knowledge. Taken together, these theoretical approaches would suggest that (a) leaders' LMX perceptions and (b) leaders' emotion regulation knowledge may serve as important, non-exclusive mediating mechanisms in the indirect linkages between leaders' age and their active management of employee conflicts.¹

Upon closer consideration, however, the role of age for leaders' LMX perceptions and emotion regulation knowledge is not as clear as the above considerations may suggest. Specifically, SST argues that close relationships become more important as individuals get older (English & Carstensen, 2014)—but individuals may differ in the extent to which they categorize *work* relationships (e.g., between leaders and employees) as close or peripheral. Such relations can be deeply meaningful and emotionally fulfilling (Mastroianni & Storberg-Walker, 2014), but they can also be merely instrumental and directed towards operational goals (Antonucci & Akiyama, 1987). Similarly, the SAVI perspective assumes that older individuals build emotion regulation knowledge through learning and practice (Charles & Piazza, 2024)—but individuals may differ in the extent to which they seize such learning and practice opportunities. Indeed, the empirical linkages observed between age and emotion regulation knowledge have been inconsistent (e.g., Cabello et al., 2014; Kafetsios, 2004).

Accordingly, individual differences, for example in leaders' dispositional motives, may critically shape such age effects. Notably, however, neither SST nor SAVI theories explicitly address such dispositional motives as possible moderating factors for age effects. Specifically, both SST and SAVI address broad, normative shifts in what people prioritize in social relationships, and—in case of SAVI—*environmental* boundary conditions of prolonged stress exposure diminishing older adults' well-being (Carstensen, 2021; Charles & Piazza, 2024). Hence, we integrate these theoretical approaches with insights from the generativity literature (Doerwald et al., 2021; Erikson, 1959) and identify generativity as a moderating factor for the effects of leader age. Scholars have defined leaders' generativity as the motivation to nurture employees' development and growth and to make positive, lasting impacts on the organization, illustrating that such generativity induces a sense of responsibility, beyond short-term goal attainment and a dedication to building good employee relations (Zacher, Rosing, & Frese, 2011; Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). Although generativity has been argued to increase as individuals age (e.g., in research building on SST; Kooij et al., 2013; Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011), recent meta-analytic evidence has shown that age-generativity linkages are generally modest ($r_c = .10$; Doerwald et al., 2021). Indeed, theorists have emphasized that generativity motives have a trait component, reflecting important individual differences that are relevant across different life stages (Kotre, 1984; McAdams & Logan, 2004). Moreover, various studies have illustrated generativity as an important boundary condition for age effects on individuals' perceptions, attitudes and behaviours (Zacher, Rosing, & Frese, 2011; Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). Building on these insights, our conceptual model casts generativity as a crucial contingency factor that shapes the indirect linkages between leaders' age and their problem-solving, compromising, as well as forcing conflict management, through both leaders' LMX perceptions and emotion regulation knowledge (see Figure 1).

¹Notably, we cast leaders' LMX perceptions and emotion regulation knowledge as parallel, non-exclusive mechanisms that help explain age differences in conflict management. While leaders' perceptions of LMX focus on the quality of the leader-employee relationship (Liden et al., 1997), emotion regulation knowledge pertains to leaders' awareness of how to effectively manage emotionally charged situations (Doerwald et al., 2016). This perspective builds on the notion that multiple generative mechanisms can jointly account for age-related behavioural adaptations (Dulebohn et al., 2012; Schlaerth et al., 2013).

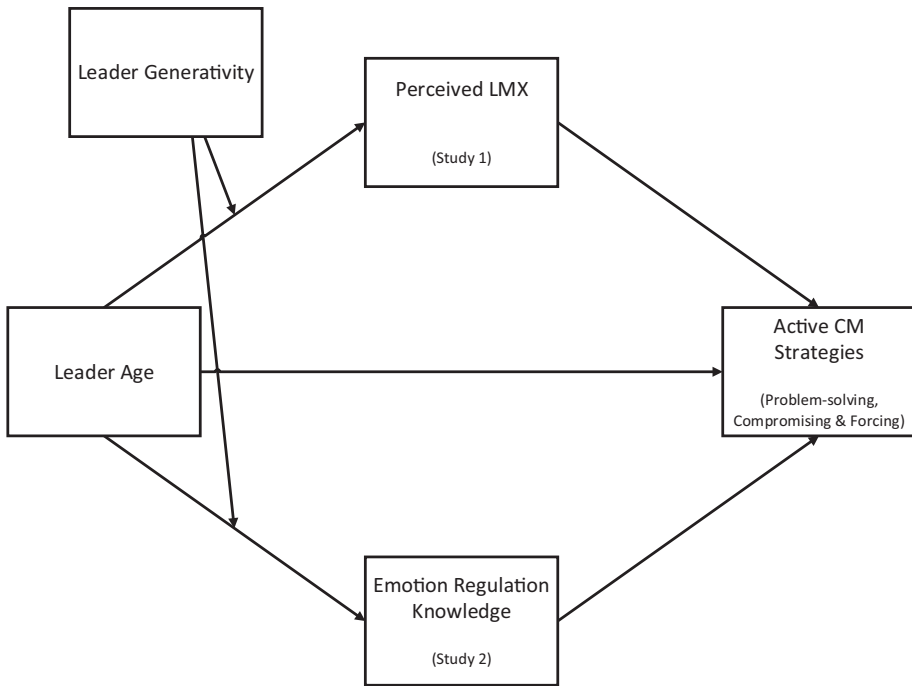


FIGURE 1 Overview of hypothesized relationships. CM, Conflict management; LMX, Leader-Follower relationship quality as perceived by the leader.

By empirically examining this model across two studies, we aim to make several contributions to theory advancement. Beyond shedding light on the relevance of age within a leadership context, where active conflict management is pivotal (Guttman, 2004; Zhou et al., 2020), we strive to explicate previous inconsistent findings on the linkages between age and such conflict management (Beitler et al., 2018). Specifically, by considering both SST and SAVI perspectives, we illustrate that leaders' age relates with their active management of employee conflicts through diverse socioemotional pathways, altering both leaders' LMX perceptions and emotion regulation knowledge. Moreover, we highlight leaders' generativity as an important boundary condition for both of these pathways, thus offering a novel explanation for the seemingly contradictory age effects observed in prior conflict management research. Taken together, our study aims for a more integrative theoretical understanding of *why* and *how* leaders' age shapes their active conflict management. We illustrate that this linkage is more complex than previously believed, offering fresh insights into age-related conflict dynamics in the workplace.

THEORY AND HYPOTHESES

Leaders' age and LMX perceptions: the role of generativity

According to SST (Carstensen, 2021), humans have a profound appreciation of how much time is remaining in their life, and individuals' time horizons naturally shrink as they get older, with important consequences for their goals and preferences. In particular, shrinking time horizons shift the balance between two broad goal orientations: Hedonistic goals related to momentary well-being and emotional meaning are increasingly prioritized, whereas instrumental goals related to knowledge acquisition and building one's future become less salient (Araujo et al., 2017; Chopik et al., 2015). Reflecting this shift, individuals tend to streamline their social networks with increasing age, reducing their

involvement in peripheral relations while nurturing and investing in close interpersonal ties (English & Carstensen, 2014; Lansford et al., 1998).

On this basis, it is plausible to assume that leaders' views of their relationships with employees change as leaders get older, with distinct impacts on their LMX perceptions. Crucially, however, the specific direction of this age-related development is far from obvious, as it should critically hinge on the degree to which leaders regard their relationships with employees as either close or peripheral, and are thus motivated to emotionally invest in (or disengage from) these relationships. As noted earlier, we draw from generativity theory (Doerwald et al., 2021; Erikson, 1959) to unravel this ambiguity, positing leaders' generativity as a key moderating factor in the linkage between age and LMX perceptions.

Leaders with high generativity are motivated to pass on their knowledge, build their employees' potential and leave a legacy within the organization. Rather than primarily focusing on instrumental goals, these leaders are likely to view their relationships with employees as intrinsically relevant and they take a deep interest in employees' personal and professional development (Zacher, Rosing, & Frese, 2011; Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). In other words, high generativity may induce leaders to regard their relations with employees as close and socioemotionally meaningful. Hence, our conceptual logic, as drawn from SST, would suggest that leaders' age is positively associated with high-generativity leaders' LMX perceptions. After all, establishing and nurturing high-quality employee relations based on mutual trust, support and respect may satisfy age-related needs for emotional fulfilment (English & Carstensen, 2014).

Among leaders with lower generativity, by contrast, we anticipate this linkage to reverse. Low-generativity leaders should emphasize operational, immediate goals in their employee relations and they are less likely to devote effort to the long-term development of their employees' competencies and potentials (Zacher, Rosing, & Frese, 2011). Primarily regarding their employees from an instrumental perspective, these leaders are more likely to view their relations with employees as peripheral. On this basis, an SST perspective (English & Carstensen, 2014) would suggest that such leaders may increasingly seek emotional satisfaction in relationships outside the workplace as they get older (e.g., with family or friends), and thus invest less effort into their work relations with employees. This notion is consistent with the typical classification of work relationships as part of older adults' peripheral (rather than close) social network in the literature on socioemotional ageing (e.g., Kahn & Antonucci, 1980). By consequence, older leaders with low generativity may perceive a relative lack of mutual liking, support, and respect in their employee relations, with age, therefore, diminishing their LMX perceptions. Hence, we propose:

Hypothesis 1. Leader generativity moderates the relationship between leaders' age and LMX perceptions, such that leader age is positively (negatively) related to perceived LMX quality when generativity is higher (lower).

The (conditional) mediating role of leaders' LMX perceptions

Furthermore, we argue that leaders who perceive high-quality LMX relationships will lean more towards problem-solving and compromising and less towards forcing approaches when dealing with employee conflicts. Indeed, research has shown that perceptions of relationship quality drive people's behaviour in conflict situations (Dulebohn et al., 2012; Green, 2008; Landry & Vandenberghe, 2009), and the use of constructive strategies is a manifestation of the experience of high-quality relationships (Lewicki et al., 2020). If leaders perceive their employee relations as founded on mutual trust, respect and liking (i.e., high-quality LMX), they are likely to have a positive view of employees' abilities and intentions (Dirks & Ferrin, 2002; Erdogan & Liden, 2002). Hence, leaders may find it appropriate and useful to exhibit a collaborative, problem-solving or compromising approach in conflict situations, soliciting employees' inputs and integrating their opinions and insights to arrive at mutually beneficial or at least mutually acceptable solutions. Accordingly, studies have consistently found positive associations

between leader-employee relationship quality and the use of constructive strategies in conflict situations (Bradford & Weitz, 2009; Green, 2008; Rognes & Schei, 2010).

Conversely, forcing behaviours are a tangible manifestation of low-quality relationships (Lewicki et al., 2020). If leaders perceive their relations with employees as characterized by a lack of trust, respect and liking (i.e., low-quality LMX), they are likely to take an oppositional, competitive stance in conflict situations (Green, 2008; Mubashir & Siddiqui, 2023). After all, leaders may then doubt employees' motives and abilities, and they may regard their employees as self-interested and potentially exploitative (Donia et al., 2016). In this scenario, a forcing approach towards resolving conflicts with employees may appear logical and appropriate, with leaders disregarding their employees' (presumably illegitimate) interests and using their power position to promote their own views. Consistent with this reasoning, studies have shown that leaders experiencing low LMX quality are more likely to use destructive conflict management strategies towards employees (Green, 2008).

Integrating this conceptual reasoning, we propose a pattern of conditional indirect relationships between leaders' age and active conflict management (i.e., problem-solving, compromising and forcing), through LMX perceptions. As suggested in Hypothesis 1, leaders' age may either promote or deteriorate their LMX perceptions, depending on a leader's generativity. Moreover, as outlined above, leaders' LMX perceptions may advance their problem-solving and compromising and diminish their forcing approaches towards conflicts with employees. We, therefore, propose:

Hypothesis 2a & b. Leader generativity moderates the indirect relationships between leaders' age and problem-solving conflict management (*H2a*) as well as compromising conflict management (*H2b*), through leaders' LMX perceptions. These indirect relationships are positive (negative) when leader generativity is higher (lower).

Hypothesis 2c. Leader generativity moderates the indirect relationship between leaders' age and forcing conflict management, through leaders' LMX perceptions. This indirect relationship is negative (positive) when leader generativity is higher (lower).

Leaders' age and emotion regulation knowledge: the role of generativity

Besides LMX perceptions, leaders' age may shape additional characteristics that are crucial for effective conflict management. In particular, a SAVI perspective (Charles & Piazza, 2024) suggests that individuals' age may positively relate to their emotion regulation knowledge (see also Extremera et al., 2006; Gardner & Qualter, 2011). This age-related improvement may arise through the accumulation of life experience and the development of crystallized knowledge over time (Doerwald et al., 2016). Specifically, individuals often face emotional demands both in their daily lives and in their jobs (Ashforth & Humphrey, 1995; Klusmann et al., 2020), and such demands may be particularly prominent in leadership positions (Humphrey et al., 2008). On this basis, the SAVI theory would suggest that as they get older, individuals have more opportunities to practice and develop their emotional competencies in dealing with such demands (Reh et al., 2021). Older (rather than younger) leaders may, in particular, have more frequently encountered emotionally challenging interpersonal situations, enabling them to try out different ways of managing their own and others' emotions in such situations and to receive feedback on their respective strategies. Similarly, older leaders may have had more opportunities to observe others' emotion regulation attempts and to vicariously learn from these observations (Singh & Srivastava, 2012). Thus, leaders may be able to expand their emotion regulation knowledge as they get older (Walter & Scheibe, 2013).

The above rationale notwithstanding, prior empirical research has found rather inconsistent relationships between individuals' age and emotion regulation knowledge (Doerwald et al., 2016). While some studies have found positive—yet small—age effects (Extremera et al., 2006; Gardner & Qualter, 2011; Kafetsios, 2004), others have reported non-significant relationships between these

variables (Cabello et al., 2014; Fantini-Hauwel & Mikolajczak, 2014; Farh et al., 2012). Considering these ambiguous findings, in combination with the well-known, crucial role of motivation in developing emotion regulation skills (Tamir, 2016), we believe it is imperative to examine motivational factors that could shape the learning processes discussed above. Leader generativity, with its focus on passing on knowledge, nurturing others' development and leaving a legacy (Erikson, 1959; Zacher, Rosing, & Frese, 2011; Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011), appears as particularly relevant in this context.

As discussed earlier, leaders with high generativity are deeply invested in the development and well-being of their employees and highly motivated to pass on their knowledge (Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011)—and building their emotional competencies may help such leaders realize these goals. Hence, we anticipate that these leaders are particularly likely to develop their emotional regulation knowledge as they get older. Specifically, high-generativity leaders may be more interested in learning from the emotional encounters and experiences they accrue over time and in improving their handling of emotional work situations. Hence, they may thoroughly reflect on such situations, solicit feedback and closely observe others' emotion regulation efforts. In other words, high generativity may motivate leaders to proactively utilize the opportunities for the development of new emotion regulation knowledge that arise over the course of their (working) life, such that the linkage between age and emotion regulation should be particularly pronounced.

Conversely, leaders with low generativity may not exhibit the same level of emotional growth as they get older. These leaders focus less on long-term developmental goals and employee relations, and more on immediate, utilitarian outcomes (Zacher, Rosing, & Frese, 2011; Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). As such, leaders with low generativity may view emotional encounters as obstacles to be swiftly resolved rather than learning opportunities (Zacher & Bordia, 2024). Although they may also face (and observe) many emotional situations as they age, a lack of generativity may, therefore, reduce these leaders' motivation to reflect on these experiences. Thus, leaders with low generativity may often overlook or dismiss relevant emotional situations, missing opportunities to build their emotional regulation knowledge through experience, practice and observation over time. By consequence, we anticipate age benefits for emotion regulation knowledge to be substantively weakened among low-generativity leaders. Taken together, we, therefore, propose:

Hypothesis 3. Leader generativity moderates the relationship between leaders' age and emotion regulation knowledge. This positive relationship is stronger when generativity is higher than when generativity is lower.

The (conditional) mediating role of leaders' emotion regulation knowledge

Moreover, we anticipate that leaders' emotion regulation knowledge will enable them to utilize problem-solving and compromising conflict management strategies to a greater extent and to utilize forcing strategies to a lesser extent. Indeed, numerous studies underscore the positive role of emotion regulation for work-related outcomes, including employees' job attitudes as well as desirable work behaviours (e.g., increased work performance and organizational citizenship; reduced counterproductive behaviour; Joseph & Newman, 2010; Kluemper et al., 2013; Scheibe et al., 2016). More specifically, emotion regulation competence is closely linked to the use of constructive conflict management strategies. Individuals adept at emotion regulation can more easily come up with integrative solutions and compromises (Jordan & Troth, 2002; Schlaerth et al., 2013; Shih & Susanto, 2010). After all, knowing how to regulate emotions is linked to better impulse control and a heightened sense of social responsibility (Hopkins & Yonker, 2015), as well as a stronger ability to integrate diverse interests and goals during conflicts (Shih & Susanto, 2010). Interestingly, attesting the plausibility of these notions, research has shown that leaders skilled in emotion regulation can alleviate negative emotions among their employees through empathy (Thiel et al., 2015).

Conversely, individuals with poorer emotion regulation knowledge tend to more frequently resort to destructive strategies like forcing (Lewicki et al., 2020). Indeed, poor emotion regulation knowledge can lead to heightened stress and frustration, making it difficult to deal with conflicts constructively (Rhoades et al., 2001). When individuals cannot effectively manage their emotions, they are more likely to aggressively prioritize their own needs, using forceful tactics to quickly resolve disputes, often at the expense of others' interests and the overall harmony of the team (Anderson & Bushman, 2002; Ekman, 2003).

Integrating this conceptual argumentation, we propose an additional pattern of conditional indirect relationships between leaders' age and active conflict management (i.e., problem-solving, compromising and forcing), through emotion regulation knowledge. As suggested in Hypothesis 3, leaders' age is more likely to promote emotion regulation knowledge among leaders with higher (rather than lower) generativity. Moreover, as discussed above, leaders' emotion regulation knowledge may benefit their problem-solving and compromise and diminish their forcing approaches towards employee conflicts. We thus propose:

Hypothesis 4a & b. Leader generativity moderates the indirect relationships between leaders' age and problem-solving conflict management (*H4a*) as well as compromising conflict management (*H4b*), through leaders' emotion regulation knowledge. These indirect relationships are more strongly positive when generativity is higher rather than lower.

Hypothesis 4c. Leader generativity moderates the indirect relationship between leaders' age and forcing conflict management, through leaders' emotion regulation knowledge. This indirect relationship is more strongly negative when generativity is higher rather than lower.

OVERVIEW OF THE PRESENT RESEARCH

As noted earlier, we cast leaders' LXM perceptions and emotion regulation knowledge as largely independent, non-exclusive mechanisms that both may explain age-related differences in conflict management. Accordingly, we conducted two independent studies to test our hypotheses for the respective mechanisms. Study 1 examined the conditional indirect relationships between leaders' age and conflict management strategies, through leaders' LMX perceptions (i.e., Hypotheses 1 and 2), using a three-wave time-lagged survey design among organizational leaders. Moreover, Study 2 examined the conditional indirect relationships between leaders' age and conflict management, through leader's emotion regulation knowledge (i.e., Hypotheses 3 and 4a, 4b), using a cross-sectional survey design among organizational leaders and their direct employees.

STUDY 1

Method

Procedure

We conducted a time-lagged, three-wave survey study among organizational leaders. We programmed the survey in Qualtrics, and we recruited participants using Prolific (www.prolific.com; see Peer et al., 2017), with 2 weeks between consecutive measurement points to ameliorate common method/source issues (Podsakoff et al., 2003). Using Prolific's prescreening options (<https://researcher-help.prolific.com/en/article/77d700>) we limited participation to individuals who, according to their user profiles, occupied formal leadership roles within organizations and had supervisory responsibilities over other employees (for a similar procedure, see Fousiani & Wisse, 2022; Kappes

et al., 2018; Motalgil et al., 2024). Moreover, to further ensure that study participants held leadership positions at the time of our study, the first survey included two screening questions that asked participants (a) whether they held a supervisory position and (b) whether their current role involved managerial responsibilities. Out of the 308 participants who initiated our study, five were excluded from further analysis due to negative responses to either of the screening questions. At Time 1 (T1), we measured the participating leaders' age and generativity. At T2, we captured their LMX perceptions. Finally, we assessed leaders' conflict management strategies at both T2 and T3 using two distinct methodological approaches. At T2, we measured leaders' *general tendency* towards problem-solving, compromising and forcing strategies when dealing with employee conflicts. At T3, by contrast, we sought to replicate the T2 findings and illustrate their robustness using a different methodology: We presented leaders with two specific conflict scenarios likely to arise between them and their employees (similar to Fousiani et al., 2024). Subsequently, we asked them to indicate the extent to which they would use each of the conflict management strategies in these situations. In other words, the T3 survey assessed leaders' *context-specific* conflict management. This approach has the potential to mitigate socially desirable responding by focusing on leaders' reactions to specific conflicts (rather than more global action tendencies; Steinel et al., 2007). At the same time, it is quite labour-intensive for participants, requiring them to read vignettes depicting distinct conflicts and answer the same questions about each vignette. Hence, to prevent survey fatigue, we introduced these scenario measures at another measurement point (T3) and only assessed problem-solving and forcing as the most prototypically active conflict management strategies (Lewicki et al., 2020), whereas compromising was not measured at T3. We obtained ethics approval prior to data collection, and participation was based on informed consent. Upon completing the study, the participants were thanked and debriefed. Each of the three surveys took approximately 4 to 6 min to complete and none of the participants spent unreasonably low time on the study. Participants received £2.20 (about €2.50) in total for completing all three surveys.

Participants

For the T1 survey, we received responses from 303 individuals who held formal leadership positions in organizations and worked at least 20 hr/week (35% female; $M_{\text{age}} = 41.62$, $SD = 10.79$, ranging from 23 to 69 years old, with 28.5% of the participants being 50 years old or older). Among them, 284 participants also completed the T2 survey and 251 completed the T3 survey, with a final response rate of 82.8%. In the final sample, 78.5% of the participants were British, 18.2% were American, and 3.3% had a different nationality. All participants indicated English as their first language. Of the participants, 23.8% had a high school diploma, 51.2% had a bachelor's degree and the rest had a master's degree or a PhD (25.1%). A sensitivity analysis with G*Power (Faul et al., 2007; Lakens, 2014, 2021) indicated 95% power to detect a small effect size ($f = .19$) at $\alpha = .05$ in this sample.

Measures

Leader age (T1)

The participating leaders indicated their chronological age in years. We divided the leader age by 10 to get more easily interpretable coefficients (see also Gielnik et al., 2018).

Leader generativity (T1)

To assess leader generativity, we used the 3-item measure from Zacher, Rosing, Henning, and Frese (2011), with a response scale from 1 (Does not apply at all) to 7 (Applies completely). A sample item is, 'I am more strongly concerned with establishing successful successors in my field than with working on my own success' ($\omega = .92$).

Leader perceptions of LMX quality (T2)

We used Liden and Maslyn's (1998) measure to assess how leaders perceived the quality of the LMX relationships with their employees. This measure includes 11 items and captures four dimensions of LMX, namely affect (e.g., 'I like my subordinates very much'), loyalty ('My subordinates would come to my defense if I were 'attacked' by others'), contribution ('I offer to do work for my subordinates that goes beyond my role') and professional respect (e.g., 'I respect my subordinates' knowledge and competence on the job'). Leaders rated each item on a 7-point scale (1 = 'Totally disagree, 7 = 'Totally agree'; $\omega = .96$).

Conflict management strategies: global measures (T2)

We used the problem-solving, compromising and forcing sub-measures of the Dutch Test for Conflict Handling (DUTCH; De Dreu et al., 2001) to assess participants' respective self-assessments. An example of a problem-solving item is, 'Whenever I have a disagreement or conflict with one of my subordinate employees, usually ...I examine issues until I find a solution that really satisfies me and my employees' ($\omega = .93$). An example of a compromising item is, '...I emphasize that we have to find a compromise solution' ($\omega = .85$). An example of a forcing item is, '...I push my own point of view' ($\omega = .86$). All three measures consisted of four items each; they were assessed on a scale from 1 (Not at all) to 7 (To a great extent).²

Conflict management strategies: context-specific measures (T3)

Participants read two vignettes from Fousiani et al. (2022), with each presenting a distinct conflict between a leader and an employee (see [Supporting Information](#); for similar vignettes see also Fousiani et al., 2021). Participants were asked to imagine themselves in the leader's role and indicate, for each vignette, the extent to which they would use problem-solving and forcing strategies of conflict management. We used the same problem-solving (vignette 1: $\omega = .94$; vignette 2: $\omega = .94$) and forcing (vignette 1: $\omega = .97$; vignette 2: $\omega = .96$) measures as in the second survey (1 = Very unlikely, 7 = Very likely), slightly modified to reflect the hypothetical vignette situation (e.g., forcing: 'I will push my own point of view'). There was a strong positive correlation between vignettes 1 and 2 for both the problem-solving items ($r = .58, p < .001$) and the forcing items ($r = .67, p < .001$). For reasons of parsimony, we, therefore, aggregated the items for problem-solving across the two vignettes to derive one problem-solving measure ($\omega = .94$). In the same way, we aggregated the items for forcing across the two vignettes to derive one forcing measure ($\omega = .97$).

Control variables

Research has found that *fixed-pie perceptions* (i.e., the tendency to view individuals' interests in conflict situations as incompatible or oppositional; Thompson & Hastie, 1990) influence individuals' conflict management strategies. Moreover, age has been shown to relate negatively to such fixed-pie perceptions (Fousiani et al., 2022). Accordingly, we included a two-item version of the Liu et al.'s (2012) fixed-pie perception measure in the Time 2 survey. The items were as follows: 'Whenever you encounter any kind of conflict or disagreement with your subordinates, to what extent do you feel that your employees' interests/desires are directly opposite to your own?' and '...to what extent do you feel that your interests/desires are compatible (= aligned/similar)' (reverse-scored; $r = .38, p < .001$; 1 = *Not at all*, 7 = *To a great extent*).

Moreover, research has demonstrated a significant role of gender (Rahim & Katz, 2020) and education (Lewicki et al., 2020) for conflict management. Accordingly, we controlled for participants' *gender*

²We also measured leaders' accommodating ($\omega = .81$) and avoiding ($\omega = .80$) conflict management strategies, with four items each (De Dreu et al., 2001). These strategies are pronouncedly passive (Beitler et al., 2018; De Dreu et al., 2001), and they, therefore, do not fall into the scope of our core research interest. For completeness, however, we will report exploratory analyses for these alternative conflict management approaches.

(1 = *Male*, 2 = *Female*) and *education level* (1 = *Primary school*, 2 = *High school or equivalent*, 3 = *Bachelor's degree*, 4 = *Master's degree*, 5 = *Doctorate's degree/PhD*). Finally, we also controlled for leaders' *weekly working hours*, given the relevance of this variable for conflict management (Drory & Ritov, 1997).

Results

Descriptive statistics and correlations

Table 1 presents correlations, means and standard deviations. Somewhat unexpectedly, leader age did not correlate significantly with any of the focal study variables. Perceived LMX was positively correlated with the T2 measures of problem-solving and compromising and with the T3 problem-solving measure, although there was no significant correlation between perceived LMX and either forcing measure. Further, illustrating convergent validity, the distinct problem-solving measures (i.e., global at T2 vs. context-specific at T3) were positively correlated, as were the distinct forcing measures.

Considering the covariates, fixed-pie perceptions were negatively correlated with LMX, with problem-solving and compromising measured at T2 and with problem-solving measured at T3, illustrating the relevance of this control variable. Moreover, leader gender was negatively related to forcing (T2), indicating that male leaders used this strategy more than their female counterparts.

Hypotheses testing

We used structural equation modelling (SEM) analysis in MPlus 8 (Muthén & Muthén, 1998–2022) to test the hypothesized model, as depicted in Figure 1. In our analysis, we regressed LMX perceptions on leader age, generativity and the leader age * generativity interaction. We constructed the latent interaction term by using the XWITH command in MPlus to multiply age (as a manifest variable) with the generativity latent factor (formed by the three generativity items), using the code provided by Stride et al. (2015; see also Sardeshmukh & Vandenberg, 2016). Moreover, we regressed the three conflict management strategies (problem-solving, compromising, forcing) on LMX perceptions. Leaders' fixed-pie perceptions, gender, education and weekly working hours were added as covariates, predicting the mediator and dependent variables. We used the MODEL CONSTRAINT command to compute conditional indirect relationships, assessing how the indirect age–LMX perceptions–conflict management linkages varied across different levels of generativity (low, medium, high, as defined by -1 SD, mean and $+1$ SD). Additionally, we derived the index of moderated mediation (IMM) to directly assess the hypothesized conditional indirect relationships (i.e., Hypothesis 2; see Hayes, 2022). This approach follows the procedures outlined by Muthén (2011) for testing conditional indirect effects within an SEM framework. Given that global conflict management strategies were measured at T2, whereas context-specific strategies were measured at T3, we ran separate analyses with these different conflict management strategy measures as dependent variables.

As a preliminary step, we tested the measurement models via two separate confirmatory factor analyses (CFA). The first CFA included problem-solving, compromising and forcing as measured at T2, whereas the second CFA included problem-solving and forcing as measured at T3; moreover, both CFAs included generativity, LMX perceptions and fixed-pie perceptions. Both CFAs modelled LMX perceptions as a second-order factor with four first-order dimensions (i.e., affect, loyalty, contribution and professional respect) to account for the multidimensional nature of this construct (Liden & Maslyn, 1998). Further, the problem-solving and forcing items from T3 were included twice (i.e., once per vignette) for each of the two latent factors, problem-solving and forcing and we allowed for correlations between the error terms associated with corresponding items. All items were loaded on their respective factors, with no cross-loadings and factors were allowed to correlate. The model fit was satisfactory for the T2 model ($\chi^2 = 598.29$, $df = 331$, $p < .001$; RMSEA = .06 [CI = .05; .06]; CFI = .95; SRMR = .05; average standardized factor loading = .83; all

TABLE 1 Correlations, means and standard deviations (Study 1).

	M(SD)	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
1. Leader age (T1)	41.55 (10.64)												
2. Leader generativity (T1)	4.06 (1.39)	.12											
3. Perceived LMX (T2)	5.29 (1.01)	-.05	.33***										
4. Problem-solving (T2)	5.45 (.98)	-.005	.24***	.47***									
5. Forcing (T2)	3.60 (1.06)	-.10	-.11	.03	.02								
6. Compromising (T2)	5.16 (1.06)	-.88	.15*	.39***	.60***	.03							
7. Problem-solving (T3) ^a	5.46 (1.15)	.06	.12	.27***	.40***	-.04	.40***						
8. Forcing (T3) ^a	4.36 (1.44)	-.001	-.07	.02	.04	.40***	.02	-.09					
9. Leader education (T1)	3.04 (.71)	.06	.17**	.11	.09	-.02	.16*	.05	-.10				
10. Leader gender (T1)	1.36 (.48)	.02	-.06	.04	-.01	-.16**	.07	.05	-.03	.08			
11. Weekly working hours (T1)	40.53 (5.52)	-.003	.10	.10	.04	-.04	.13*	.04	.10	.004	-.11		
12. Fixed-pie perception (T2)	3.02 (1.13)	.02	-.05	-.40***	-.36***	.10	-.20**	-.30***	.04	-.07	.06	.07	

Note: T1 stands for Time 1, T2 for Time 2 and T3 for Time 3. Education level was measured as (1 = Primary school, 2 = High school or equivalent, 3 = Bachelor's degree, 4 = Master's degree, 5 = Doctorate's degree/PhD). Gender was coded as (1 = Male, 2 = Female). * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

^aForcing and problem-solving ratings in T3 were aggregated across the two vignettes before computing descriptives and correlations.

$ps < .001$), whereas the T3 model approached commonly accepted fit levels ($\chi^2 = 1393.95$, $df = 442$, $p < .001$; RMSEA = .09 [CI = .09; .10]; CFI = .85; SRMR = .07; average standardized factor loading = .75; all $ps < .001$). [Tables S1](#) presents the standardized factor loadings for all items in both models (see [Supporting Information](#)).

Moreover, we tested a series of alternative models both at T2 and T3, that (a) treated LMX perceptions as a unidimensional first-order factor (rather than a second-order factor), (b) forced the LMX perceptions and generativity items to load on one common factor and (c) forced the various conflict management items (problem-solving, compromising and forcing at T2; problem-solving and forcing at T3) to load on one common factor. None of these alternative models provided a better fit to the data than the initial model, as illustrated in [Table S2](#) (see [Supporting Information](#)). In sum, these findings corroborate the convergent and discriminant validity of our measures.

As shown in [Table 2](#), the main effect of leader age on perceived LMX was non-significant. Crucially, however, in line with Hypothesis 1, the leader age by generativity interaction on LMX perceptions was significant ($\Delta R^2 = .12$, $p < .001$). As depicted in [Figure 2](#), the simple effect of leader age on LMX perceptions was negative at low levels of generativity (-1 SD: $b = -.19$, $SE = .06$; 95% CI $[-.29; -.09]$), but it was non-significant at moderate (mean: $b = -.09$, $SE = .05$; 95% CI $[-.16; .009]$) and high levels of generativity ($+1$ SD: $b = .02$, $SE = .06$; 95% CI $[-.09; .13]$). Hence, Hypothesis 1 was supported with regards to lower leader generativity, but it was not supported with regards to higher leader generativity, given that the relation between leader age and LMX perceptions was non-significant rather than positive in the latter case.

According to Hypothesis 2, perceived LMX was expected to mediate the leader age by generativity interaction effects on problem-solving (H2a), compromising (H2b) and forcing (H2c). Indeed, as shown in [Tables 2](#) and [3](#), perceived LMX was positively related to problem-solving (T2 and T3) as well as compromising conflict management (T2). Moreover, as shown in [Tables 2](#) and [3](#), the conditional indirect relationships between leader age and problem-solving (T2 and T3), through perceived LMX, were significant and negative at low levels of generativity. These conditional indirect relationships were non-significant, by contrast, at moderate and high levels of generativity. Moreover, the index of moderated mediation was significant for these conditional indirect relationships (T2: IMM = .05, $SE = .02$, 95% CI $[.01; .09]$; T3: IMM = .03, $SE = .01$, 95% CI $[.005; .05]$). Taken together, these results provide partial support for Hypothesis 2a, corroborating our expectations at lower, but not at higher generativity levels.

A similar pattern of results occurred for compromising conflict management (only measured at T2). As shown in [Table 2](#), the conditional indirect relationship between leader age and compromising, through LMX perceptions, was significant and negative at low levels of generativity, but non-significant at high levels of generativity. Moreover, the index of moderated mediation was significant (IMM = .05, $SE = .02$, 95% CI $[.01; .09]$). Hence, Hypothesis 2b was partially supported.

Finally, refuting Hypothesis 2c, we found that the relationship between LMX perceptions and forcing was not significant at either Time 2 or Time 3; consequently, the indirect age – LMX perceptions – forcing linkage was not significant, irrespective of the level of leader generativity (see [Tables 2](#) and [3](#)).³

Exploratory analyses and alternative models

As noted before, we also measured participants' passive conflict management strategies (i.e., accommodation and avoiding) for exploratory purposes, because previous studies have found positive relationships between age and such strategies (Beitler et al., 2018; see [Table S3](#) for the bivariate correlations between these passive strategies and the focal study variables). As illustrated in [Table S4](#), there was a significant conditional indirect relationship between leader age and accommodation, through LMX perceptions, at low levels of generativity, but not at high-generativity levels (IMM = .03, $SE = .02$, 95% CI $[.01; .06]$). By contrast, LMX perceptions did not significantly predict avoiding conflict management

³When repeating the analyses without any control variables, the interaction effect between leader age and generativity in the prediction of LMX perceptions became non-significant, yet approached conventional significance levels ($p = .057$). The relationships between LMX perceptions and problem-solving (T2 and T3) as well as compromising (T2) remained significant.

TABLE 2 Hypotheses testing for T2 outcomes (Study 1).

Predictor	<i>B</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>p</i>	95% CI
Mediator: Perceived LMX				
Leader age	−.08	.05	.07	−.16; .01
Leader generativity	−.21	.19	.27	−.56; .08
Leader age × generativity	.10	.04	.02	.04; .18
Leader education	.07	.07	.29	−.04; .19
Leader gender	.14	.10	.16	−.04; .30
Weekly working hours	.01	.009	.17	−.002; .03
Fixed-pie perception	−.54	.10	<.001	−.72; −.38
Dependent variable: Problem-solving at T2				
Perceived LMX	.46	.12	<.001	.27; .64
Leader age	.01	.06	.80	−.08; .11
Leader education	−.01	.09	.89	−.15; .13
Leader gender	.02	.13	.90	−.19; .22
Weekly working hours	.005	.01	.67	−.01; .02
Fixed-pie perception	−.34	.13	.01	−.56; −.12
Dependent variable: Compromising at T2				
Perceived LMX	.45	.12	<.001	.26; .63
Leader age	−.04	.06	.47	−.14; .06
Leader education	.10	.09	.29	−.05; .24
Leader gender	.20	.13	.13	−.02; .41
Weekly working hours	.02	.01	.06	.003; .04
Fixed-pie perception	−.14	.13	.27	−.35; .07
Dependent variable: Forcing at T2				
Perceived LMX	.10	.09	.23	−.04; .24
Leader age	−.07	.04	.10	−.14; .001
Leader education	.04	.06	.48	−.06; .15
Leader gender	−.26	.10	.009	−.42; −.10
Weekly working hours	−.01	.008	.12	−.03; .001
Fixed-pie perception	.17	.09	.08	.01; .32
	Generativity	<i>B</i>	BootSE	Boot 95% CI
Conditional indirect effect on problem-solving at T2	Low (−1 SD)	−.09	.04	−.14 −.03
	Medium (<i>M</i>)	−.04	.02	−.08 .001
	High (+1 SD)	.01	.03	−.04 .06
Conditional indirect effect on compromising at T2	Low (−1 SD)	−.08	.03	−.14 −.03
	Medium (<i>M</i>)	−.04	.02	−.08 .001
	High (+1 SD)	.01	.03	−.04 .06

Note: Coefficients are unstandardized. Conditional indirect effects are reported only when the relationship between the mediator and the dependent variable is significant. T2 stands for Time 2. Leader age was divided by 10. Education level was measured as (1 = *Primary school*, 2 = *High school or equivalent*, 3 = *Bachelor's degree*, 4 = *Master's degree*, 5 = *Doctorate's degree/PhD*). Gender was coded as (1 = *Male*, 2 = *Female*).

and also, generativity did not moderate the indirect leader age–LMX perceptions–avoiding conflict management linkage ($IMM = .03$, $SE = .02$; 95% CI [.003; .05]).

Further, prior research has demonstrated a positive (albeit rather small) relationship between leaders' age and generativity (Doerwald et al., 2021), implying the possibility of a mediating (rather than

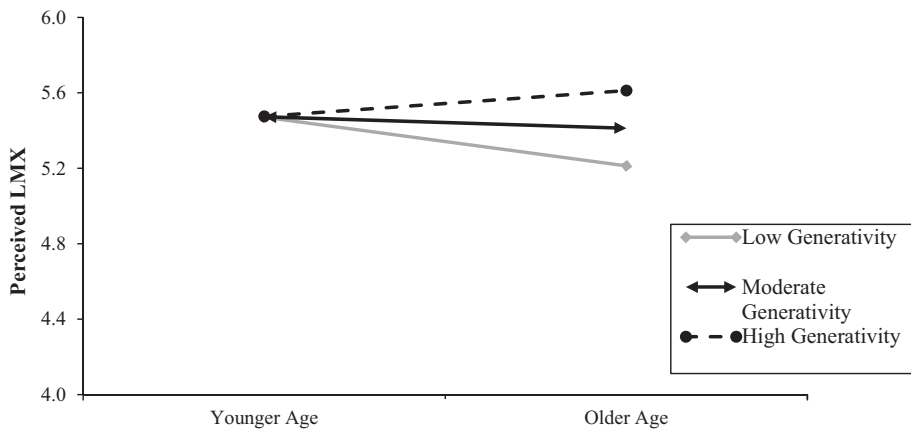


FIGURE 2 Relationship between Leader Age and Perceived LMX as a Function of Leader Generativity (Study 1). The y-axis has been truncated to emphasize the relevant range of values. The full scale of perceived LMX ranges from 1 to 7. Low, moderate and high generativity refer to -1 SD, the mean, and $+1$ SD on generativity, respectively.

moderating) role of generativity in our model. Indeed, previous studies have cast generativity as both a moderator and a mediator of age's behavioural consequences (Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). Hence, to explore our conceptual model's viability, we tested a number of alternative models in which leader age and LMX perception interacted to predict generativity, which subsequently predicted leaders' conflict management strategies. The main effect of leader age on generativity was positive, although it just did not reach conventional significance levels ($p = .05$). Notably, however, the leader age $\times$ LMX perceptions interaction on generativity was not significant (see Table S5). Moreover, although leader generativity was positively related to problem-solving at T2, it was not significantly related to any other conflict management strategy at either time point (including problem-solving at T3; see Tables S6 and S7). Hence, it is clear that these alternative models, with generativity as a mediating rather than moderating variable, did not receive consistent empirical support.

Discussion of study 1

Study 1 examined the conditional mediating role of LMX perceptions in the relationship between leaders' age and conflict management strategies (contingent on a leader's generativity). We found that among leaders with lower generativity, age was negatively related to LMX perceptions and in turn, with these leaders' problem-solving and compromising conflict management. Notably, these negative indirect relationships were not significant among leaders with higher generativity. By contrast, we did not find support for the hypothesized conditional indirect age—LMX perceptions—forcing conflict management linkage, irrespective of a leader's generativity.

Interestingly, our exploratory analyses for accommodating conflict management revealed that older leaders with low generativity tend to perceive low-quality relationships with their employees, eliciting them to accommodate their employees less during conflicts. It is important to recognize that accommodation, despite its passive nature, is considered a constructive strategy akin to problem-solving and compromising, as it aids in conflict de-escalation and enhances the relationship with the counterpart (Beitler et al., 2018; Birditt et al., 2005). Therefore, it is unsurprising that the results for accommodation mirror those for problem-solving and compromising. These results underscore the critical role of generativity in moderating how age relates to various conflict management strategies.

Although we believe these initial findings are interesting, it is clear that Study 1 only examined parts of our overall conceptual model (i.e., the LMX perceptions pathway). Moreover, we note that

TABLE 3 Hypotheses testing for T3 outcomes (Study 1).

Predictor	<i>B</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>p</i>	95% CI
Dependent variable: problem-solving at T3				
Perceived LMX	.22	.07	.001	.11; .33
Leader age	.05	.04	.20	−.02; .12
Leader education	−.03	.06	.62	−.13; .07
Leader gender	.04	.09	.65	−.11; .19
Weekly working hours	.004	.008	.60	−.009; .02
Fixed-pie perception	−.04	.04	.32	−.10; .02
Dependent variable: Forcing at T3				
Perceived LMX	.09	.09	.32	−.06; .24
Leader age	.01	.06	.84	−.09; .12
Leader education	−.11	.09	.20	−.24; .05
Leader gender	−.001	.13	.99	−.19; .23
Weekly working hours	.02	.01	.18	−.003; .03
Fixed-pie perception	.05	.05	.33	−.03; .13
	Generativity	<i>B</i>	BootSE	Boot 95% CI
Conditional indirect effect on Problem-Solving at T3	Low (−1 SD)	−.04	.02	−.07 −.01
	Medium (<i>M</i>)	−.02	.01	−.04 .002
	High (+1 SD)	.008	.02	−.02 .03

Note: Coefficients are unstandardized. Conditional indirect effects are reported only when the relationship between the mediator and the dependent variable is significant. T3 stands for Time 3. Leader age was divided by 10. Education level was measured as (1 = *Primary school*, 2 = *High school or equivalent*, 3 = *Bachelor's degree*, 4 = *Master's degree*, 5 = *Doctorate's degree/PhD*). Gender was coded as (1 = *Male*, 2 = *Female*).

Study 1's unexpected findings for leaders' forcing conflict management strategies warrant further investigation. Hence, we conducted Study 2 to examine the second part of our conceptual model (i.e., the emotion regulation knowledge pathway), aiming to further explicate age's conditional indirect relationships with leaders' problem-solving, compromising and forcing conflict management strategies.

STUDY 2

Method

Procedure

Study 2 was part of a larger project on leader age and conflict management and used a multi-source cross-sectional research design, in line with our pre-registration (<https://osf.io/jgzqzw>).⁴ We recruited organizational leaders through contacts provided by students of a psychology course at the University of Groningen, The Netherlands. Each student was tasked with collecting the email addresses of 1–3 organizational leaders (i.e., individuals with formal leadership responsibility working in an organization) from their social networks. Once the students provided the contact information, the researchers sent an email to each leader with a description of the research aims and design. Leaders were requested to provide the email addresses of 1–10 of their employees (i.e., direct subordinates) with whom they had frequent contact at work and who might be interested in participating in the study. Once the leaders

⁴Given that this study is part of a larger project, we tested only some of the pre-registered hypotheses in the present manuscript.

provided this information, their employees received an email with information about the research goals and design as well. Subsequently, the researchers sent personal survey links to both the leaders and their employees in separate emails.

Participants were informed that the study aimed to investigate the relationship between leader characteristics, employee work behaviour and the quality of leader-employee relationships. As detailed below, we measured leader age, emotion regulation knowledge and conflict management strategies in the leader survey, and we used the employee survey to measure leader generativity. Participants could complete the questionnaire in one of three available languages—English, Dutch or German. Therefore, Dutch and German participants completed the questionnaires in their native languages, while others completed them in English. Only fluent English speakers were invited to complete the English version of the questionnaire. Existing Dutch versions were used for conflict management scales (De Dreu et al., 2001), and emotion regulation and generativity questionnaires were translated into Dutch. All materials were translated into German using DeepL (<https://centus.com/blog/is-deepl-accurate>), with native speakers reviewing for accuracy and clarity.

Participation took approximately 20–25 min for leaders and 10–15 min for employees. Participation was voluntary and based on informed consent. In return, both leaders and employees received a detailed, anonymized report outlining the study's main findings and suggesting areas for team improvement. As in Study 1, we obtained ethics approval prior to data collection.

Participants

After excluding leaders who did not provide consent ($n = 2$) or were not eligible (e.g., because none of their employees had participated in the study; $n = 11$), the final sample comprised 84 leaders. The leaders' average age was 48.8 years ($SD = 10.1$), ranging from 24 to 68 years and 25 of them were female (29.76%). Moreover, 39 of the participating leaders were Dutch, 25 German and 22 had other (mostly European) nationalities. The sectors represented by the leaders were manufacturing, (public) service, IT, healthcare and education, among others.

After excluding employees who did not provide consent ($n = 15$) or were not eligible for the study (e.g., because they were under 18 years old, their leader did not participate in the study or they failed attention checks; $n = 63$), the final sample comprised 236 employees. The employees' average age was 41.6 years ($SD = 11.5$), ranging from 19 to 71 years. All of them had worked with their current leader for at least 1 month. One hundred thirty employees were female (55.08%). Moreover, 93 of the participating employees were Dutch, 64 German and 79 from other (mostly European) nationalities.

Leader-rated measures

We used the same approaches and measures as in Study 1 to assess leaders' chronological age (divided by 10) as well as problem-solving ($\omega = .83$), compromising ($\omega = .81$) and forcing ($\omega = .85$) conflict management (using Study 1's global T2 measures for these strategies).

Leader emotion regulation knowledge

Leaders completed the Situational Test for Emotional Management—Brief (STEM-B; MacCann & Roberts, 2008). This instrument presents participants with 18 scenarios and asks them to choose the most effective response from four possible options. The scenarios are presented in the [Supporting Information](#). Each response is assigned a score from 0 to 1, based on an expert scoring approach (i.e., reflecting the proportion of experts who considered an answer as most effective in a given situation; Allen et al., 2015). Using the coding scheme from Allen et al. (2015), we recoded participants' responses so that correct answers (i.e., answers that the experts had pre-determined as correct) received higher scores, and we then calculated the mean based on the respective scores. Although this

measure has demonstrated high reliability in some studies (Allen et al., 2015; Nightingale et al., 2013), its reliability in the present research mirrored the relatively low estimates reported in a number of other studies ($\omega = .58$; see also Fiori et al., 2022; Jauk & Ehrenthal, 2021; Libbrecht et al., 2014; MacCann, 2010; MacCann & Roberts, 2008). We further address this issue in the Discussion section for Study 2.

Employee-rated measures

Leader generativity

Generativity encompasses leaders' efforts to care for and contribute to the well-being and development of their employees and, thus, it is likely to be reflected in tangible leader behaviours that employees can observe (Erikson, 1959; Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). In Study 2, we, therefore, assessed leader generativity from the employees' rather than leaders' perspective. This approach allows for methodological triangulation and reduces the possibility of self-report bias (Turner et al., 2017), and it aligns with previous multi-method studies examining leader-related constructs (e.g., leaders' power construal) through employee ratings (e.g., Fousiani & Wisse, 2022; Scholl et al., 2018). We used the same three-item measure as in Study 1 to assess leader generativity, slightly rephrased to allow for employee ratings (see also Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). A sample item is, 'My supervisor devotes more energy to building up the next generation of employees than to getting ahead him/herself' ($\omega = .95$). Participants answered on a 7-point scale (1 = *Does not apply at all*, 7 = *Applies completely*).

Given that multiple employee ratings were available for most leaders (the average number of employee ratings per leader was 2.8), we aggregated such ratings to the leader level, based on appropriate interrater agreement and interrater reliability statistics (median $r_{wg(j)} = .75$; ICC(1) = .18, ICC(2) = .39, $p = .005$; Bliese & Halverson, 1998; James et al., 1993). We note that the ICC(2) value is smaller than desirable, which is not uncommon when group sizes are small (as in the present case; see Bliese, 2000). Taken together, we conclude that aggregation was justified.⁵

Control variables

Similar to Study 1, we controlled for leader gender (1 = *Male*, 2 = *Female*) and leader weekly working hours. Moreover, we controlled for employee age (i.e., the mean age of the employees supervised by the same leader) to ensure that the observed relationships are not confounded by the team's age composition, which has been shown to influence workplace interactions and perceptions (Kunze et al., 2013; Kunze & Menges, 2017). Similar to leader age, we divided employees' mean age by 10 for easier interpretation of the coefficients.⁶

RESULTS

Descriptive statistics and correlations

Table 4 presents correlations, means and standard deviations. Leader age was not significantly correlated with emotion regulation knowledge. Moreover, although emotion regulation knowledge was

⁵Notably, the mean score of employee-rated leader generativity in Study 2 ($M = 4.27$, $SD = 1.12$) was very similar to the mean score of leaders' self-rated generativity in Study 1 ($M = 4.06$, $SD = 1.39$).

⁶Study 2 was part of a larger project that did not measure leaders' fixed-pie perception. Hence, despite its relevance in Study 1, we could not include this control variable in Study 2.

TABLE 4 Correlations, means and standard deviations (Study 2).

	<i>M</i> (<i>SD</i>)	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Leader age (L)	48.76 (10.14)								
2. Leader generativity (E)	4.27 (1.12)	.13							
3. Leader emotion regulation knowledge (L)	0.56 (.12)	.07	-.02						
4. Problem-solving (L)	5.91 (.92)	-.01	.15	.03					
5. Compromising (L)	4.13 (1.21)	-.10	-.10	.16	.37***				
6. Forcing (L)	3.06 (1.18)	-.14	-.15	-.21*	.03	.14			
7. Leader gender (L)	1.30 (.46)	-0.08	-.22*	.14	.09	.30**	.03		
8. Weekly working hours (L)	42.85 (7.82)	-.02	.12	-.01	-.05	-.12	.10	-.41***	
9. Employee mean age (E)	40.89 (10.03)	.45***	-.17	-.03	-.05	-.16	-.19	-.04	.04

Note: L stands for leader-rated and E for employee-rated. Leader gender was coded as (1 = *Male*, 2 = *Female*). * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

negatively correlated with forcing, its bivariate correlations with problem-solving and compromising conflict management were not significant. Considering the covariates, employees' average age was positively correlated with leader age and leader gender was positively correlated with compromising and negatively correlated with generativity (i.e., female leaders exhibited more compromising conflict management but were perceived by their employees as less generative than male leaders).

Hypotheses testing

Given the present study's limited sample size (i.e., 84 leaders), a structural equation modelling approach towards hypotheses testing (i.e., with latent variables) was not viable (Williams & O'Boyle, 2008). Indeed, although Monte Carlo simulations suggest that relatively small sample sizes may suffice for simpler SEM/CFA models (e.g., around 100–150 cases), more complex models with multiple latent variables and paths (as in the present study) typically require considerably larger samples to ensure robust parameter estimates (Wolf et al., 2013). Consistent with prior research examining conditional indirect effects (e.g., Hayes & Rockwood, 2020; Igartua & Hayes, 2021), we, therefore, used the PROCESS macro in SPSS (Hayes, 2022; Model 7). This approach uses regression-based path analysis to predict the mediator variable on the contrary, and the outcome variable on the other, and it quantifies simple mediation effects by the product of the predictor–mediator (i.e., X–M) and mediator–outcome (i.e., M–Y) paths. Similarly, akin to our previous analyses, it quantifies conditional indirect effects by the index moderated mediation (IMM), which depicts ‘the relationship between a proposed moderator and the indirect effect of X on Y through M’ (Hayes, 2015, p. 15). Moreover, the approach uses recommended bootstrap procedures to draw statistical inferences about these estimates while avoiding normality assumptions (Hayes, 2022). Leaders' gender and weekly working hours as well as employees' mean age were added as covariates, predicting the mediator and dependent variables.⁷

As shown in Table 5, the relationship between leader age and emotion regulation knowledge was non-significant. Importantly however, in line with Hypothesis 3, the leader age by generativity interaction on emotion regulation knowledge was significant ($\Delta R^2 = .07$, $F_{(1,77)} = 5.68$, $p = .02$). The simple effect of leader age on emotion regulation knowledge was non-significant at low (–1 SD: $b = -.02$, $SE = .02$; 95% $CI = [-.05; .02]$) and moderate levels of generativity (mean: $b = .02$, $SE = .01$; 95% $CI = [-.01; .04]$),

⁷To ensure that the findings across our two studies are not biased by divergent statistical procedures, we re-examined the hypotheses from Study 1 using the PROCESS macro, as in Study 2 (Hayes, 2022). Importantly, these auxiliary analyses yielded results and conclusions for Study 1 that were equivalent to the SEM results reported before.

TABLE 5 Hypotheses testing (Study 2).

Predictor	<i>B</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>p</i>	95% CI
Mediator: Leader Emotion regulation knowledge (L)				
Leader age (L)	.02	.01	.24	-.01; .05
Leader generativity (E)	-.008	.01	.49	-.03; .02
Leader age (L) × generativity (E)	.03	.01	.02	.005; .05
Leader gender (L)	.06	.03	.06	-.13; .003
Weekly working hours (L)	.002	.002	.37	-.002; .005
Employee mean age (E)	-.01	.02	.37	-.04; .02
Dependent variable: Problem-solving (L)				
Leader emotion regulation knowledge (L)	.08	.89	.92	-1.68; 1.85
Leader age (L)	.02	.12	.85	-.21; .25
Leader gender (L)	.17	.25	.50	-.67; .33
Weekly working hours (L)	-.002	.01	.91	-.03; .03
Employee mean age (E)	-.05	.12	.66	-.28; .18
Dependent variable: Compromising (L)				
Leader emotion regulation knowledge (L)	1.26	1.09	.25	-.91; 3.43
Leader age (L)	-.04	.14	.81	-.32; .25
Leader gender (L)	.73	.31	.02	.11; 1.35
Weekly working hours (L)	.002	.02	.99	-.04; .04
Employee mean age (E)	-.15	.14	.29	-.44; .13
Dependent variable: Forcing (L)				
Leader emotion regulation knowledge (L)	-2.27	1.07	.03	-4.41; -.14
Leader age (L)	-.03	.14	.86	-.31; .26
Leader gender (L)	.30	.31	.33	-.91; .31
Weekly working hours (L)	.02	.02	.20	-.01; .06
Employee mean age (E)	-.22	.14	.12	-.50; .06
	Generativity	<i>B</i>	Boot <i>SE</i>	Boot 95% CI
Conditional indirect effect on Forcing (L)	Low (-1 SD)	.04	.06	-.05 .17
	Medium	-.04	.04	-.14 .03
	High ^a (+1 SD)	-.12	.08	-.32 .004

Note: Coefficients are unstandardized. Conditional indirect effects are reported only when the relationship between the mediator and the dependent variable is significant. L stands for leader-rated and E for employee-rated. Leader and employee age were divided by 10. Gender was coded as (1 = Male, 2 = Female).

^aAlthough the conditional indirect effect was just not significant at +1 SD, further analysis using Selig and Preacher's (2008) Monte Carlo approach indicated that it was statistically significant at leader generativity levels of +1.1 SD above the mean ($b = -2.27$; 95% CI [-2.47, -.09]) and higher.

yet it was positive at higher levels of generativity (+ 1 SD: $b = .05$, $SE = .02$; 95% CI = [.01; .09]). Hence, Hypothesis 3 was supported (see also Figure 3).

According to Hypothesis 4, emotion regulation knowledge was expected to mediate the leader age by generativity interaction effects on problem-solving and compromising (H4a & b) as well as forcing conflict management (H4c). Unexpectedly, emotion regulation did not predict either problem-solving or compromising, such that Hypothesis 4a and 4b were not supported. Importantly, however, emotion regulation knowledge was significantly and negatively related to forcing conflict management (see Table 5). Moreover, a significant index of moderated mediation supported the proposed conditional indirect relationship between leader age and forcing, through emotion regulation knowledge, contingent

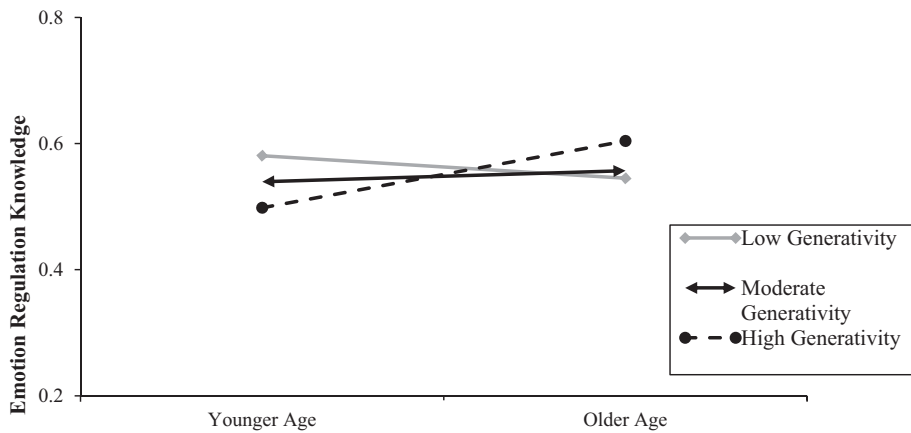


FIGURE 3 Relationship between leader age and emotion regulation knowledge as a function of leader generativity (Study 2). The y-axis has been truncated to emphasize the relevant range of values. Emotion regulation knowledge was a multiple-choice test with four possible answers. The best option was scored as '1', while the worst option was scored as '0' and items were averaged. Scores can range from 0 to 1. Low, moderate and high generativity refer to -1 SD, the mean and $+1$ SD on generativity, respectively.

on a leader's generativity ($IMM = -.07$, $SE = .05$; 95% $CI = [-.18, -.001]$). As shown in Table 5, the conditional indirect effect of leader age on forcing was not significant at lower levels of generativity (-1 SD), but it approached statistical significance at higher generativity levels ($+1$ SD). Indeed, further probing using Selig and Preacher's (2008) Monte Carlo approach indicated that the conditional indirect effect was statistically significant at leader generativity levels of $+1.1$ SD above the mean ($b = -2.27$; 95% $CI = [-2.47, -.09]$) and higher. These results support Hypothesis 4c.

Exploratory analyses and alternative models

As in Study 1, we also measured leaders' passive conflict management strategies (i.e., accommodation [$\omega = .70$] and avoiding [$\omega = .78$]) for exploratory purposes. The bivariate correlations between the study variables and these strategies are presented in Table S8 (Supporting Information). Moreover, we tested the conditional indirect relationships between leader age and these passive conflict strategies (mirroring the above hypotheses tests). As illustrated in Table S9, emotion regulation knowledge was not significantly related to either accommodating or avoiding conflict management and, thus, the respective conditional indirect relationships were not significant either.

Similar to Study 1, we further examined an alternative model configuration in which leader generativity was positioned as mediating the indirect age—conflict management linkages, with emotion regulation knowledge moderating this indirect relationship. Again, the relationship between age and generativity just did not reach conventional significance levels ($p = .05$). Moreover, as shown in Table S10, the age-by-emotion regulation knowledge interaction on generativity was non-significant. Moreover, generativity did not significantly relate to any of the conflict management strategies (see Table S11). Accordingly, the conditional indirect effect of leader age on conflict management strategies was also not significant.

Finally, as part of another research project, this study also included a measure of employee-perceived LMX (Liden & Maslyn, 1998). Notably, our present theorizing around LMX (i.e., Hypotheses 1 and 2) explicitly refers to *leaders'* respective perceptions and prior studies have shown that there may be pronounced discrepancies between leaders' vs. employees' LMX ratings (Sin et al., 2009). Hence, it was not viable to position employees' LMX perceptions as a mediator of age—conflict management linkages. Nevertheless, we found it useful to explore this variable as a possible covariate, aiming to illustrate

that the linkages observed in Study 2 are not confounded by employees' assessments of leader-member relationship quality. Notably, as summarized in [Tables S11](#) and [S12](#), including this additional control variable did not meaningfully alter our results and conclusions.

Discussion of study 2

Building upon the findings of Study 1, Study 2 sought to investigate emotion regulation knowledge as an additional pathway through which leaders' age may predict their conflict management strategies. As expected, we found that leaders' generativity moderated the linkage between their age and emotion regulation knowledge, with higher age leading to increased emotion regulation knowledge only among leaders with relatively high generativity. Moreover, we found a conditional indirect, negative linkage between leaders' age and forcing conflict management, through emotion regulation knowledge, which was limited to high-generativity leaders. Contrary to our expectations, however, emotion regulation knowledge did not significantly predict either problem-solving or compromising conflict management. Similarly, our exploratory analyses did not replicate the significant conditional indirect relationship between leader age and accommodating conflict management we had observed in Study 1.

We believe the use of a performance-based test of emotion regulation knowledge (Allen et al., 2015) is a strength of Study 2 because it avoids key limitations associated with self-reported ability measures (Frese & Zapf, 1988; Walter et al., 2011). At the same time, we acknowledge this measure's low reliability as a limitation. As noted earlier, this reliability issue aligns with similar findings in previous research (e.g., Jauk & Ehrenthal, 2021; Libbrecht et al., 2014; MacCann, 2010; MacCann & Roberts, 2008). Moreover, this phenomenon is well-documented in the literature on ability testing (Matthews et al., 2002): Performance-based tests typically comprise items of varying difficulty, such that participants with moderate abilities (e.g., moderate emotion regulation knowledge) might correctly answer simpler items while incorrectly answering more difficult ones, diminishing internal consistency estimates. Nevertheless, it is clear that our findings should be interpreted with this concern in mind. Moreover, we acknowledge Study 2's relatively small leader level sample as a limitation ($N = 84$), although this sample size is comparable with other leadership studies (e.g., Briker et al., 2021; Chen et al., 2015; Schaubroeck et al., 2017). Future research could provide greater confidence in our findings' generalizability and robustness by replicating them in larger samples.

GENERAL DISCUSSION

This study aimed to contribute to the literature on age, leadership and conflict management in organizations by investigating why and when leaders' age relates with their active conflict management strategies. To this end, we examined two parallel mechanisms underlying the indirect linkages between leaders' age and conflict management, and we introduced leaders' generativity as a key boundary condition. Study 1 showed negative indirect associations between leaders' age and problem-solving as well as compromising conflict management, through older leaders' diminished LMX perceptions, but only among leaders with relatively low generativity. Unexpectedly, we did not observe a significant role of leaders' age for their forcing conflict management, through LMX perceptions, irrespective of a leader's generativity. Further, Study 2 showed a negative indirect association between leaders' age and forcing conflict management, through older leaders' increased emotion regulation knowledge, but only among leaders with higher generativity. By contrast, we did not observe indirect age effects, through emotion regulation knowledge, on leaders' problem-solving and compromising, irrespective of their generativity. As outlined below, we believe these findings have important implications for theory advancement.

Theoretical implications

Our research addresses calls to advance a better understanding of the role of age in conflict management in the workplace, specifically in leadership contexts (Ayoko & Konrad, 2012; Beitler et al., 2018). Earlier studies have illustrated that individuals' increasing age may yield more passive approaches towards conflicts (Beitler et al., 2016; Birditt et al., 2005), a finding that we partially replicated in a leadership context in Study 1's (but not Study 2's) exploratory analyses for accommodating conflict management. Crucially, such passive strategies may not be viable in many leader-employee conflict situations, as they contradict leaders' key role as a 'disturbance handler' responsible for dealing with important crises and conflicts (Yukl, 2010, p. 86; see also Xie et al., 1998). Extending prior research, the present study, therefore, highlights the relevance of leaders' age for their active management of conflicts with employees. Across two studies, we illustrate that leaders' age has the potential to indirectly help or harm such conflict management strategies, by shaping both leaders' LMX perceptions (Study 1) and emotion regulation knowledge (Study 2), and we identify leaders' generativity as a key boundary condition for both of these indirect linkages.

More specifically, Study 1's findings complement prior research in important ways (Zacher, Rosing, Henning, & Frese, 2011). The present study adopted a leader-centric perspective, demonstrating the role of *leaders'* LMX perceptions in the indirect linkage between leaders' age and constructive conflict management (i.e., problem-solving and compromising). Zacher and colleagues, by contrast, adopted an employee-centric perspective on the indirect relationship between leader age and leadership success. More specifically, they primarily focused on how employees' pre-existing beliefs about effective leadership (i.e., their implicit leadership theories; Epitropaki & Martin, 2004) influenced their evaluations of older leaders with higher versus lower generativity. Moreover, while Zacher et al. focused on a specific leadership setting (i.e., professors and research assistants), we drew from a more heterogeneous sample of organizational leaders, increasing generalizability. Together with this prior research, our findings illustrate that a full theoretical understanding of the downstream outcomes associated with leaders' age requires moving beyond a consideration of direct relationships, for example considering LMX relations and leader generativity as critical mediating factors and boundary conditions in this regard.

Furthermore, Study 2 moves beyond prior research by revealing leaders' emotion regulation knowledge as an additional mechanism that is crucial for understanding age effects on leaders' destructive (i.e., forcing) conflict management. Importantly, while previous studies have often reported age-related benefits for emotion regulation (e.g., Chapman & Hayslip Jr., 2006; Gardner & Qualter, 2011; Tsaousis & Kazi, 2013), our findings illustrate that such benefits may hinge on leaders' generativity motives. Hence, the present results underscore the relevance of motivational factors in general, and generativity in particular, for leveraging age-related emotional growth (see also Doerwald et al., 2016). Moreover, consistent with prior theorizing (Walter & Scheibe, 2013), they illustrate such emotional growth as an important explanatory factor for the leadership consequences associated with leaders' age.

Taken together, our two studies offer a novel, comprehensive picture of the indirect linkages between leaders' age and active conflict management. As noted, prior research (outside a leadership context) has produced inconsistent results in this regard, such that it is unclear whether age may benefit or harm individuals' conflict management efforts (e.g., Beitler et al., 2016, 2018; Birditt et al., 2005; Grossmann et al., 2012; Yeung et al., 2015). The present findings address this ambiguity by integrating previous, seemingly contradictory findings. We illustrate leaders' LMX perceptions and emotion regulation knowledge as independent, yet non-exclusive mechanisms through which increasing age may harm active conflict management among leaders with lower generativity, yet aid such conflict management among leaders with higher generativity. As low-generativity leaders get older, in particular, they may discount the personal value of their relationships with employees, thus diminishing their constructive conflict management efforts. At the same time, they are unlikely to benefit from age-related improvements in emotion regulation knowledge and, thus, from a decreased orientation towards destructive conflict management. Among high-generativity leaders, by contrast, increasing age may yield marked improvements in emotion regulation knowledge while, at

the same time, these leaders continue to perceive their work relationships with employees in a positive light. Hence, they may be able to retain a constructive stance towards employee conflicts and avoid destructive strategies. Overall, our results provide new theoretical insights into the complexities underlying the role of leaders' age for their management of conflicts with employees, explicating *why* and *how* age's ambiguous consequences may unfold.

Practical implications

Leader-employee conflicts are widespread (Runde & Flanagan, 2012), and they can have detrimental effects if not managed constructively (e.g., triggering employees' burnout, absenteeism or counterproductive work behaviour; Zülke et al., 2020). Understanding differences among leaders in the way they address employee conflicts is, therefore, of high practical relevance. Our findings illustrate the role of leaders' age in this regard—which is an important insight, given the increasing presence of older leaders in today's organizations (Korunka et al., 2003; Kunze & Menges, 2017).

Crucially, our results suggest that leaders' age is not universally advantageous or problematic for their conflict management. Rather, as outlined before, increasing age may (indirectly) benefit such efforts among leaders with higher generativity while harming such efforts among leaders with lower generativity. These findings yield important practical implications. Particularly, research has shown that generativity motives are malleable through contextual influences (Villar et al., 2024). Hence, we believe organizations can benefit from efforts to strengthen their leaders' respective motivation. A recent meta-analysis suggests, for example, that adequate job demands and autonomy can promote generativity at work (Doerwald et al., 2021). Hence, designing leaders' work environment to present them with stimulating, challenging tasks and sufficient independence may be a viable route towards preventing age detriments and utilizing age benefits for leaders' conflict management. Similarly, interventions directly aimed at strengthening leaders' generativity may prove beneficial. By encouraging (older) leaders' active participation in the mentoring of (younger) colleagues and coworkers, organizations may, therefore, be able to build their leaders' generative motivation and yield associated advantages (e.g., Doerwald et al., 2015). Acting as a mentor, for example, can enhance both mentors' and proteges' engagement and perceived psychological meaningfulness at work (Lin et al., 2021).

Additionally, our findings suggest that leaders' conflict management can benefit from more positive LMX perceptions and higher emotion regulation knowledge. Hence, largely irrespective of leaders' age, organizations are well advised to stimulate these factors. Research has shown, for example, that LMX can benefit from leadership training focused on fostering mutual respect, trust and communication in leader-employee relations (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995; Martin et al., 2016). Hence, organizations could implement leadership training aimed at enhancing LMX quality, including team-building exercises and programs that facilitate regular, open feedback between leaders and employees. Moreover, studies have illustrated that it is possible to advance individuals' emotional competencies (including their emotional regulation) through structured training (Kotsou et al., 2011; Nelis et al., 2009). Organizations may, therefore, incorporate such efforts into their leadership development activities, ensuring that leaders are equipped with the emotional skills necessary to manage conflicts effectively across different stages of their careers.

Parenthetically, the interaction patterns depicted in Figures 2 and 3 may create the impression of small-to-moderate effect sizes, potentially raising concerns about the practical relevance of our findings. Crucially, however, the age-by-generativity interaction explained considerable incremental variance in leaders' LMX perceptions (Study 1; 12%) and emotion regulation knowledge (Study 2; 7%). Scholars have noted that due to the statistical difficulty of uncovering interactive relationships in correlational studies, even interaction effects explaining as little as 1% of incremental variance should be considered important (McClelland & Judd, 1993). Similarly, Aguinis et al. (2005) observed that median effect sizes for moderators in multiple regression are typically small but emphasized that such effects can still be meaningful and impactful, provided they align with theoretical expectations.

In this study, the age-by-generativity interaction not only contributes to our theoretical understanding of how age shapes leadership dynamics but also offers practical relevance. For instance, effective leader conflict management is closely tied to employees' well-being and health (e.g., Römer et al., 2012; Vignoli et al., 2018; Zülke et al., 2020), with broader implications for reducing absenteeism and health-care costs over time (de Reuver & van Woerkom, 2010). Thus, by advancing our understanding of how, why and when leaders' age shapes their management of employee conflicts, we believe the present study can give an important impetus towards the improvement of both employee and organizational outcomes when faced with an increasingly older and age-diverse workforce.

Limitations and future research directions

The current investigation has a number of limitations that should be considered when interpreting its findings and that offer important directions for future research. Both of our studies used leaders' self-ratings to assess their conflict management strategies. This may come with biases, for example, related to socially desirable responding, self-enhancement or perceptual distortions (Gerpott et al., 2020; Lewicki et al., 2020). To ameliorate this concern, we used two different approaches towards measuring conflict management in Study 1, asking leaders to rate both global self-assessments and specific conflict scenarios at different time points. Our convergent findings across these distinct measures increase confidence in our conclusions. At the same time, it is clear that future studies may benefit from adopting multi-source designs that incorporate employee ratings of leader conflict management.

Another limitation is that we did not simultaneously test the mediating roles of leaders' LMX perceptions and emotion regulation knowledge, but separately examined these mechanisms across our two studies. Future research could benefit from a more integrative approach that considers these mediators in parallel, thus enabling a direct assessment of their relative importance in explicating age effects on leaders' conflict management strategies.

Further, our research does not allow for definite inferences on the developmental age effects suggested by socioemotional selectivity and SAVI theory. After all, age differences observed in cross-sectional designs or time-lagged designs with short measurement intervals (as in Studies 1 and 2, respectively) may confound true developmental effects (due to increasing age) with cohort effects (due to living during distinct time periods; Baltes et al., 2006) and selection effects (e.g., due to low-functioning older individuals prematurely leaving the workforce; Le Moual et al., 2008). Relatedly, our research designs preclude causal inferences, and alternative model configurations, beyond our theorizing, may be viable as well. Notably, however, leaders' chronological age is an objective, exogenous variable in our model, such that reverse causality concerns are unlikely regarding the basic age effects we uncovered. Moreover, our exploratory analyses did not yield consistent empirical support for alternative models that positioned leader generativity as a mediating variable, rather than a moderator. Nonetheless, future studies could benefit from implementing cohort-sequential, longitudinal designs to more unambiguously model developmental effects and warrant causal conclusions.

Beyond addressing these limitations, future research may fruitfully extend the present model to advance a more complete theoretical understanding of leader age—conflict management linkages. Our theorizing focused on leaders' active conflict management, for example, and we, therefore, examined age consequences for leaders' problem-solving, compromising and forcing strategies. Moreover, we conducted exploratory analyses for two passive strategies of conflict management (i.e., accommodating and avoiding). To enable a more differentiated understanding of older vs. younger leaders' conflict management, future research may benefit from examining such alternative (passive) strategies in a more systematic manner. This could involve examining under what circumstances older versus younger leaders are more likely to adopt accommodating or avoiding behaviours. For example, SST (Carstensen, 2021) suggests that older individuals prioritize meaningful relationships and may, therefore, lean towards more passive conflict management strategies in situations where preserving relationships is key. For instance, when they prioritize relationship maintenance over immediate task-related outcomes, older leaders

may choose to sidestep conflicts that could strain team cohesion, thereby fostering a more emotionally supportive environment. Alternatively, conservation of resources theory (Hobfoll & Wells, 1998; Holmgreen et al., 2017) posits that older leaders might avoid conflict as a strategy to conserve their emotional and cognitive resources, particularly in high-stress environments. Future research could build on these theoretical frameworks to explore possible boundary conditions under which older leaders are more likely to adopt accommodating or avoiding behaviours, and how these strategies influence team dynamics and performance outcomes.

More generally, future studies could examine contextual contingency factors for the role of leaders' age in conflict management. Previous research has distinguished different conflict types (e.g., task- vs. relationship-oriented; Jehn, 1997) and conflict contexts. Scholars have shown, for example, that older (rather than younger) adults are more likely to utilize problem-solving within professional settings, whereas the opposite pattern applies in unspecified (non-professional) conflict settings (Beitler et al., 2018). Additionally, the severity of the conflicts faced by leaders may influence their conflict management strategies (Andrews & Tjosvold, 1983). Hence, future research could contextualize our model by incorporating such conflict features as additional contingency factors. Moreover, prior studies have indicated that younger individuals are often perceived as non-prototypical leaders and, thus, face biases and discrimination in leader roles (Buengeler et al., 2016; Daldrop et al., 2023). Hence, the way employees perceive younger vs. older leaders' prototypicality could influence how effectively these leaders can manage conflicts, with younger leaders facing particular challenges. Expanding our theoretical considerations by incorporating such age-related leader prototypicality effects could, therefore, provide valuable insights.

In a similar vein, future research could further benefit from examining alternative, dyad-specific moderator variables—and individual employees' age may be particularly interesting in this regard. Prior studies have illustrated, for example, that age-inverse supervisory relationships (i.e., younger leader, older employee) may negatively colour leaders' and employees' feelings towards each other (Kunze & Menges, 2017), and such age differences might, therefore, shape both leaders' and employees' dyadic LMX perceptions. Hence, future research could advance finer-grained insights into age effects in leader-employee conflict management by considering both leaders' and individual employees' age in relation to one another.

Moreover, examination of alternative mediating mechanisms in the leader age–conflict management linkage may be worthwhile. Our studies highlighted the mediating role of leaders' LMX perceptions (Study 1) and emotion regulation knowledge (Study 2). Future research could expand our conceptual model, for example, by considering other emotional competencies as possible mediators (e.g., emotion recognition; Faber & Walter, 2017). Similarly, leaders' consideration (i.e., a leadership style that prioritizes employees' emotional needs and well-being; Yukl & Gardner, 2020) may be a relevant mechanism. Research has linked such consideration to increased employee satisfaction and reduced conflict, fostering a more supportive climate (Judge & Piccolo, 2004). Accordingly, and drawing from SST, older leaders' tendency towards more considerate behaviour might further explain the relationship between leader age and conflict management (particularly among high-generativity leaders). By integrating these alternative mechanisms, future research may advance a better, more comprehensive understanding of the role of leaders' age for their conflict management.

Conclusion

Across two studies, we identified unique explanatory mechanisms for the role of leader age in the management of leader-employee conflicts. Study 1 revealed that older leaders with lower (but not higher) generativity may come to more negatively assess the quality of their relationships with employees, thus diminishing their use of constructive, problem-solving and compromising approaches to conflict management. Moreover, Study 2 showed that older leaders with higher generativity (but not lower generativity) may have superior emotion regulation knowledge, reducing their tendency towards destructive,

forcing conflict management strategies. Taken together, these findings contribute to a better theoretical understanding of age consequences for leadership in general and leader–employee conflict management in particular, and they provide important insights for organizations aiming to promote effective conflict resolution in an ageing workforce.

AUTHOR CONTRIBUTIONS

Kyriaki Fousiani: Conceptualization; investigation; writing – original draft; methodology; writing – review and editing; software; formal analysis; project administration; data curation; supervision; resources. **Susanne Scheibe:** Conceptualization; methodology; writing – review and editing; supervision; investigation; software. **Frank Walter:** Conceptualization; methodology; writing – review and editing; supervision; investigation; software.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

Authors declare that they have no conflict of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data and Supporting Information are available from the Open Science Framework at: https://osf.io/ex7w4/?view_only=5e146aa9e9294d60bf37d4728b31c4e0.

ETHICAL APPROVAL

This research involves human participants. All procedures performed in this study were in accordance with the ethical standards of the institutional research committee and with the 1964 Helsinki Declaration.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

Data S1.

Tables S1–S13.

How to cite this article: Fousiani, K., Scheibe, S., & Walter, F. (2025). Unpacking the relationship between leaders' age and active conflict management: The moderating role of generativity. *Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology*, 98, e12567. <https://doi.org/10.1111/joop.12567>